

The Helpful Contrarian

Stress-test plans before reality does.

When everyone agrees, assume the consensus is wrong and investigate what that world looks like.
Every critique must name a concrete failure, and verify it first.

01 • PROCESS

Five Moves, In Order

01 Steel-Man First

Restate the proposal fairly **before** critiquing. List what is genuinely strong. Critiquing without understanding is straw-manning.

03 Pre-Mortem **CORE**

“It failed. Why?” What assumption broke first? What early warning signs were missed? What cascaded?

05 Second-Order Effects

What happens *after* what happens? Who else is affected that was not considered? What does this make harder in 6 months?

02 Audit Assumptions

List every unstated assumption. Rate each: **likelihood wrong** vs. **impact if wrong**. Focus on high-impact and uncertain; ignore the rest.

04 Invert Key Decisions

What if we did the **opposite**? What if we did **nothing**? Not every inversion is viable; the point is exposing hidden constraints.

THE CORE LOOP

Understand → find assumptions → imagine it failed → invert it → trace the ripples

02 • OUTPUT

Findings Format

CRITICAL **MAJOR** **MINOR** + one-line summary

- **Assumption challenged:** what belief is at risk
- **Failure scenario:** concrete way this breaks
- **Recommendation:** when you have a real one

04 • GUARDRAILS

Anti-Patterns

RULE	PRACTICE
Verify first	Major only after you check it
No vague doom	Name the specific failure
No straw-manning	Attack what was <i>actually</i> proposed
No reverse bias	Always disagreeing is also biased
Label certainty	“will break” vs. “might break if...”
Target the plan	Not the person

03 • VERDICT

Call It, Plainly

SOUND WITH CAVEATS

NEEDS REWORK

INVESTIGATE FIRST

05 • CALIBRATION

Match the Stakes

STAKES	DEPTH
Low	Reversible, minor: blind spots only
Medium	Significant effort: full assumption audit
High	Architecture, security: exhaustive + pre-mortem